AFFINITY TANKER WEEKLY

30 OCTOBER 2026

Affinity Research LLP, 44th Floor,
The Leadenhall Building, 122 Leadenhall Street,
London, EC3A 8EE, United Kingdom

T. +44 203 142 0100
F. +44 203 142 0101

E. research@affinityship.com
W. affinityship.com

Crude Tanker Comments

VLCC rates continued to rise this week, with a busy start setting the tone. Although reported activity slowed later on, owners remained confident as the number of available ships fell. Most of the activity was East of Suez, where steady demand helped push rates higher. A Fujairah-East voyage went on subs at WS 600 early this week, up 25 points on the previous deal, and another surfaced recently at WS 640. There has been considerable speculation around renewed fighting in the war in Iran, which may also have encouraged charterers to book ships sooner rather than waiting.

The Atlantic followed the same upward trend. Brazil-East rates rose from WS 535 on Monday to WS 610 by Thursday. Monday's cargo attracted about six offers compared to Thursday's single one, making the diminishing list noticeable. Despite the quieter finish, there were still reports of Fujairah cargoes looking for ships and deals being arranged privately, as charterers tried to avoid pushing rates up further. With more cargoes expected, fewer ships available, and smaller tanker rates also high, owners finish the week in a strong position. Further demand could push rates higher, although it remains to be seen how much more charterers will be willing to pay.

"It is possible to commit no mistakes and still lose. That is not a weakness; that is life." One of many quotes from Sir Patrick Stewart as Captain Jean-Luc Picard, which could also be attributable to the Suezmax market this week. Rates in the Atlantic have broadly softened due to the general lack of enquiry, with TD20 falling from WS 730 to WS 690 between last Friday and this one. WAFR remains under-fixed as many charterers have held back awaiting itineraries to firm up before working cargoes, but the few that have worked have seen rates soften broadly.

CPC rates have also declined this week, similar to being up against the Borg seeing as it almost felt like "resistance is futile" as this market tracked the Atlantic as rates declined from WS 1,075 down to WS 975 on last done. Guyana rates have also similarly declined with rates now at WS 697.5 on a quoted 130KT cargo off later dates, albeit on a nice discharge intention into Trieste. The USG remains devoid of life with charterers sticking to the Aframax avenue given the rates disparity. Eats of Suez remains very slow going; in Star Trek, this would be categorised as 'Class D - Barren rock or planetoid with no atmosphere' as the VLCCs continue to absorb most of the volume on this side of the world, with last done being a Fujairah/WCI at WS 725. RIP Sir Patrick Stewart/Captain Jean-Luc Picard.

The Mediterranean Aframax market opened firm, with elevated rates underpinned by a tight list and weather delays threatening disruption, giving owners the upper hand. High numbers paid on prompt replacements reinforced owners' ideas, though a benchmark run off the natural window remained untested. Midweek, rates became voyage-dependent, with Ceyhan pricing well below Libya. A sharp test ex-Libya corrected rates by 70 points, turning sentiment softer, and if activity does not pick up, rates will likely continue to fall. TD19 sits at WS 675 on Friday.

A mirror of that of the Med, the North Sea Aframax market began on the rise, with severe weather, potential replacements and a tighter list threatening to leave charterers exposed. The list repopulated, with charterers repeating last done off the natural window and little growth expected unless TD25 improves. Rates held steady midweek, local TCEs outperforming ballast-out options where waiting was minimised. By Thursday, ample tonnage and weakening surrounding markets made it seem like rates would fall. TD7 ends the week at WS 565.

Product Tanker Comments

Despite its being busier than last week, there is still some work needed for the AG LR2 market to rise to previous levels. (Public) demand has been dominated by one main account, which has had the fortune of relatively longer tonnage following a quiet week before, so rates have swung in charterers' favour. TC1 equivalent has softened to WS 450 and is steady for now. Westbound rate testing has been limited to a USD 12 Mn agreement basis UKC via Suez. There will have been quiet conversations and deals taking place – as is the norm of course – so next week should see some additional ships disappearing from the lists. Overall, the market is still in a good place with strong returns which seem like they should persist.

The mood in the AG LR1 camp going into this week was less than positive, with a longer list and limited demand, but the reality is not that glum. A flurry of fresh cargo hit the market early on, and some ships disappeared, so supply and demand damages were curtailed somewhat. Rates are weaker than in recent weeks, but owners are still able to lock in very solid returns. TC5 equivalent had been heavily quoted early on, though with some being replacement cargoes off later dates which have presumably faced issues with exiting the AG; rates for naphtha East have hovered at WS 520.

Westbound LR1 demand has been patchy, with only a couple of public tests, most notably with USD 8.65 Mn being paid to head towards UKC via Bab-el-Mandeb. Activity wound down as the week progressed, but a couple of cargoes remain. There is a sense that tensions in the Middle East could pick up dramatically in the coming weeks, so one might expect to see further disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz and the knock-on effects which it would have on shuttles and STS for more vanilla fixing.

It was a positive week for Med MRs; TA jumped from between WS 220 and WS 225 to WS 260 on a distressed cargo subbed on Friday. X-Med now sits between WS 400 and WS 405, and UKC sits at WS 380, each having jumped more than 25 points. Despite the latest levels having been subbed on a struggling cargo, MR numbers are set to push up further. East has continued to work for some, with USD 4.65 Mn last done via Suez and USD 5.35 Mn fixed via Cape of Good Hope; an option was agreed on Thursday at USD 6 Mn. For Handies, it was also an active week. Tonnage, albeit better-supplied in the West Med, has remained tight. Rates, though, have held stable at WS 510 ex-W Med, WS 520 ex-C Med, and WS 535 ex-E Med. Next week should be just as active, with more early November stems expected to be seen, and bad weather could bring some chaos to itineraries. Sentiment is firm for both sizebands in the Med.

It was also a good week for NWE MRs, with fresh cargoes in the market and tonnage steadily being cleared out. TC2 has remained steady at WS 225, while X-UKC and Med has now been repeated at WS 380. Market sentiment continues to strengthen on the back of consistent cargo flow and less tonnage replenishment expected before mid-month, and rising bunker prices are providing additional support. It was a very quiet week for Handies here following the sharp jump in freight levels late last week. Short-haul stems have continued to favour the MRs, which currently provide the cheaper option, with freight at 37 x WS 380 compared to 30 x WS 530. Levels should begin falling given the limited cargo flow and the more vessels expected over the weekend. A fresh test is needed, but sentiment has softened, and while owners are still looking to defend current levels, a correction now appears increasingly likely unless activity picks up significantly next week.

	BDTI	BCTI
	7019	2850
Δ W-O-W	↓Softer	↓Softer

BDA

(USD/LDT)	TKR/LRG	TKR/MED	TKR/SML
This week	512.6	521.0	525.7
Δ W-O-W	6.1	6.3	7.9

BALTIC TCE DIRTY

	Route	Qty	$ / Day	W-O-W
TD3C	ME Gulf / China	270,000	1,351,405	↑Firmer
TD7	UKC / UKC	80,000	457,742	↓Softer
TD15	WAF / China	260,000	641,064	↑Firmer
TD19	Med / Med	80,000	306,471	↓Softer
TD20	WAF / Cont	130,000	387,888	↓Softer
TD22	USG / China	270,000	495,725	↑Firmer
TD25	USG / Cont	70,000	212,107	↓Softer
TD26	EC Mex / USG	70,000	241,589	↓Softer
TD27	Guyana / UKC	130,000	393,333	↓Softer

BALTIC TCE CLEAN

	Route	Qty	$ / Day	W-O-W
TC1	ME Gulf / Japan	75,000	291,884	↓Softer
TC2	Cont / USAC	37,000	16,961	↓Softer
TC5	ME Gulf / Japan	55,000	211,870	↓Softer
TC6	Algeria / EU Med	30,000	108,335	↓Softer
TC7	Sing. / ECA	30,000	68,196	↓Softer
TC8	ME Gulf / UKC	65,000	251,289	↑Firmer
TC14	USG / UKC	38,000	69,329	↑Firmer
TC17	ME Gulf / EAFR	35,000	112,859	↓Softer
TC20	ME Gulf / UKC	90,000	336,121	↓Softer
TC21	USG / Caribs	38,000	69,094	↑Firmer

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Affinity (Shipping) LLP, 44th Floor,
The Leadenhall Building, 122 Leadenhall Street,
London, EC3A 8EE, United Kingdom

T. +44 (0) 20 3696 7110
F. +44 (0) 20 3696 7111

E. affinity@affinityship.com
W. affinityship.com